

Tsuemi-hime and the Seven Forest Spirits

御杖の谷の昔話

Prologue — The Ancient Gift

Long ago, Princess **Yamatohime-no-Mikoto**—daughter of heaven—walked the valleys of Yamato on a sacred mission: to find a perfect home for Amaterasu, the Sun Goddess. When she descended into a mist-wrapped valley, she felt something holy. She left her sacred staff planted in the earth—not because she was tired, but because it became a promise. The valley kept the staff and kept the promise, becoming **御杖**—"the honorable staff."

Chapter 1 — The Kingdom Asleep

Centuries later, **Tsuemi-hime** lived in that same valley—not as a princess of palaces, but as a mountain princess. She was quick-footed on mossy trails, could read weather from birdsong, and wore a spiraled lock of hair, a mark of Yamatohime's blessing. Mitsue was beautiful—cherry blossoms in spring, fireflies in summer, maple in autumn, ice on peaks in winter. But something went wrong: young people left for cities, schools closed, fields fell idle, and the **forests changed**—evergreen cedar plantations replaced native oaks and maples. Bears wandered into villages because nut trees were gone. And the **Sugi Witch** lived in the dark center of this gray-green monoculture.

Chapter 2 — The Sugi Witch's Mirror

The Witch did not look like a witch—she looked like a spreadsheet. She was the spirit of short-term economics: planting one profitable tree in every direction and calling it a forest. Each morning she asked her mirror: *"Which Japanese village shall never rise? Which shall never see the light?"* The mirror answered: *Mitsue. Population 1,393 and falling. School closed. Young people: gone.* But one spring morning, the mirror flickered. Something was moving in the valley that had no place in her numbers.

Chapter 3 — The Wanderer from the Sea

There came to Mitsue a man from a distant northern country—**Rob**—who had arrived in Japan as a young man and was shaped by radiation-counting work after Fukushima. He had come not to visit but to **stay**—on a floating house by a mountain stream. After watching the valley for years, he spoke to Tsuemi-hime: *"Your valley is not dying. It is sleeping under a spell. And I think I know how to break it—but I cannot do it alone."* "Then we will look for help," said Tsuemi-hime, tapping her staff. "Together we will find the Seven."

Chapter 4 — The Seven Forest Spirits

Deep in the mountains, seven spirits lived and worked—each the guardian of one piece of what the valley needed:

- **Mori**, Forest Keeper — plants acorns and native trees, reads soil maps, argues with plantation owners. *"Ecological restoration is not a sprint. Minimum 25 years."*
- **Bio**, Heat-Keeper — tends a biomass boiler, heating the old school with local wood. *"Heat first, electricity second."*
- **Tane**, Seed Planter — collects seeds of native trees, patient and young. *"In 25 years, this will be a broadleaf forest again."*
- **Deta**, Data Keeper — builds community-owned digital infrastructure run on local energy. *"A data center doesn't have to be a hyperscale monster. It just has to be here, and ours, and on."*
- **Denki**, Spark-Maker — manages EV charging stations powered by Bio's energy. *"Energy sovereignty is our vision."*
- **Akari**, Light-Sharer — documents everything: species counts, temperatures, server uptime. *"Documentation is a deliverable. Not an afterthought."*
- **Gate**, Funding Guardian — stands at the door between each phase. *"Phase 1 does not begin until Gate 1 is cleared."*

Chapter 5 — Two Sages at the Edge of the Wood

Before beginning, they sought counsel from two great sages—**Joi** (former head of a great technology institute) and **Ray** (architect of invisible digital systems). "Advisory commitments confirmed. Phase 0 may proceed," said Gate.

Chapter 6 — The Poisoned School

The Sugi Witch, watching from her mirror, cast the spell of **accumulated neglect** on the old school—maintenance costs, asbestos inspections, permits, insurance, institutional hesitation. When Tsuemi-hime and Rob came to the grey school, they found a door swollen in its frame, windows clouded with grime, lights that wouldn't switch on. Tsuemi-hime pressed her hand to the cold wall and felt faintly the warmth of children who had once run these corridors. "It is not dead," she said. "It is waiting."

Chapter 7 — The Breaking of the Spell

The spell broke not with a kiss but with a stamp—the red stamp of the Legal Affairs Bureau acknowledging the founding of the **Mitsue Project General Incorporated Association**. Founding members: Rob and Yuka, his partner who saw from the beginning what the valley could become. When the stamp came down, something shifted in the cedar forest. The spell thinned. Mori planted three more oaks. Bio felt steadier flame. Deta powered on the first server. Gate opened his ledger to a new page. And at Mitsue Shrine, cherry blossoms opened ten days before forecast.

Chapter 8 — The Long Work

The witch was not gone. Spells of economic neglect do not break in a single stamp. "Then we will have planted trees, trained people, documented what we learned, and left the school better than we found it," said Tsuemi-hime. "That is not failure. That is Phase 0."

Epilogue — Twenty-Five Years Later

The cedar rows are gone from south-facing slopes. In their place: young oaks, maples, kaya nuts, mountain cherry, with selective stands of timber cedar managed on rotation. Below, at the old school: lights are on. The building has been carefully renovated—insulated, weatherproofed, wood floors polished. The data center hums with servers run on biomass boiler, solar panels, and micro-hydro turbine. The village owns it. Seven other villages in Nara and Mie prefectures have built their own versions, using Akari's openly published documentation. And at Mitsue Shrine, when the autumn festival comes, a child asks her grandmother: "*Why is the village called Mitsue?*" And the grandmother says: "*Because a princess left her staff here, and the valley kept the promise.*"

And they all lived long, slowly, and open-source forever after.